After our membership of the OIC, it is possible that a door may be opened for interference by the QIC in our internal affairs on a regular basis. Our past experience of participating in the Islamic conference at Rabat in 1969 was also not encouraging. In that conference India was treated shabbily, though the meeting was held at the government level. Our ambassador had even addressed the conference but no one raised an objection. It was on the behest of Pakistan that on 24 September objection was raised to our presence there. India's membership of this organization does not appear to be of any particular advantage for India. The development of bilateral relations by India with these countries is going on smoothly and may be further intensified. It seems to promise a brighter future for India's relations with Muslim states than the membership of QIC.

The India-Iran relationship was seriously compromised because of Khomeini's tough stand against the USA and its perceived allies. Diplomats struggled to find an important Shia leader who would stand up for India because without influence of that nature, any diplomatic effort would be futile. Vipul's boss, codenamed Anil Prasad, tossed him a difficult question: 'Can you win Khomeini's trust for India, mollify the agitating political leaders and neutralise the Pakistani influence in Iran?

Are you capable and confident of launching a third-country operation without stepping into Iran?'

Vipul told me he felt as though his head had been struck by a hammer.

'But I have never said no to an operation/ he added. 'And here I was being handed a job that the entire diplomatic community had failed to deliver. It would be a lie to say that I was confident. I was damn nervous and it showed on my face. Nevertheless, I